Google Civic Information API: Capabilities & App Ideas

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> **Key fact:** Google shut down the Representatives API (the "who are my officials" lookup) in April 2025. What remains is useful mainly around elections. The US general election is on Nov 3, 2026.

What the API can still do (v2)

Base URL: `https://www.googleapis.com/civicinfo/v2`

Method	Call	What you get
`electionQuery`	`GET /elections`	A list of upcoming elections the API has data for: ID, name, date, and the area it covers (an `ocdDivisionId`, a standard code like `ocd-division/country:us/state:fl`)
`voterInfoQuery`	`GET /voterinfo?address=...&electionId=...`	The main one. For a registered address: polling places, early-vote sites, ballot drop-off locations, races and candidates on the ballot, ballot measures, and links to state and county election offices
`divisions.search`	`GET /divisions?query=...`	Search political districts by name or code
`divisionsByAddress`	`GET /divisionsByAddress?address=...`	Every district code that covers an address (congressional, state legislative, county, city, school board)

Data you can get from voterinfo

- **Polling places:** address, hours, and notes
- **Early voting sites and drop-off locations,** with their dates and hours
- **Contests:** each race's office, level (federal, state or local), district, and candidates (name, party, website, social links where available)
- **Referenda:** title, subtitle, and the pro/con statement text
- **State and local election office info:** registration URL, absentee ballot URL, election rules URL, phone numbers, and addresses

Limits

- **There's no representatives data anymore.** To get officials, look up district codes with `divisionsByAddress`, then match them against a third-party source such as Cicero, BallotReady, or Ballotpedia.
- **`voterinfo` data only exists near an election.** Between elections it often comes back empty, and coverage depends on how much each state and county reports. Test with real Florida addresses before committing to it.
- **It's US-only.** You need an API key from your Google Cloud project. Keep the key on the server side or restrict it in the console.

App ideas

1. **"Where do I vote?" finder:** enter an address and see your polling place, early-vote sites, and drop boxes on a Google Map, with hours. The simplest app that delivers real value.
2. **Sample ballot preview:** shows each race and measure on your ballot, with candidate links. Users save their picks and print a checklist to take to the polls.
3. **Election countdown and reminders:** pulls the elections that apply to your address, then sends calendar or email reminders for early voting and Election Day.
4. **"Know your districts" explainer:** turns district codes into plain language ("You're in FL-23, State Senate 35, Broward School Board District 4"). Pair it with a third-party API to show the officials too.
5. **Campus voter hub for FAU students:** a dorm address or ZIP shows the nearest polling site, and the app links to the state registration and absentee pages that `voterinfo` returns.

Recommendation for a class project: #1 or #2, because they rely only on what the API reliably returns.

Documentation

- Main reference: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2
- voterInfoQuery: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2/elections/voterInfoQuery
- divisionsByAddress: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2/divisions/divisionsByAddress
- Python client reference: developers.google.com/resources/api-libraries/documentation/civicinfo/v2/python/latest/

Sources

- Civic Information API v2 reference (Google)
- Notice of Turndown of the Representatives API (Google Group)